nothing to it, ‘it would be easy’.[71] The thirteen-year-old – the same age as Akbar when Bairam crowned him in Kalanaur – and accustomed all his short life to accepting the instruction and aid of aggressive adults, agreed.

It was a pathetically weak-kneed siege. Hakim camped in a garden outside Lahore; Akbar heard the news, the ‘flames of [his] wrath . . . burst forth’ and he marched out of Agra. He had only reached Delhi when Hakim ran away – terrified by ‘the reverberation’ of Akbar’s approach.[72]

Akbar continued his march anyway; and so we reach the scene of his vast and bloody qamargah hunt.[73]

The sheer scale of it – 15,000 animals, according to Badauni, were trapped in the qamargah circle – suggests that it was a means to shock and awe in the absence of a war. Even so, the enormous hunt did not sap all of Akbar’s adrenalin and anger, still burning in his brother’s wake. He returned to Lahore at a full gallop, insisting on swimming his horse to the city across the Ravi river. The accompanying nobility plunged in behind him, dutifully, and two of them drowned, including the messenger Khushkhabar Khan – perhaps unpopular despite his name, for his sudden death elicited a cruel rhyme that begins ‘Khushkhabar Khan is bad news . . .’[74]

There is a telling parallel to this anecdote from Humayun’s life. During one of his eternal pursuits of Kamran, Humayun rode across a stream on horseback. As Abul Fazl tells it, not one of his chiefs followed; instead, they meandered away, ‘seeking a safe passage’.[75] Humayun was upset; he told them all a peevish tale of how a Persian shah’s followers had thrown themselves off a cliff to catch his falling handkerchief. His chiefs, no doubt, pretended to listen.

How things had changed. The Ravi, writes Abul Fazl, ‘flows with ocean-like majesty’, yet the force of Akbar’s authority was stronger still. Unfortunately for Ali Quli and the Uzbeks, they could not see, or would not accept, the changing protocols of court – just as they were ignorant of, or unwilling to accept, news of Hakim’s humiliating retreat. Thus it was that now, as Akbar secured his borders in the north, word arrived from the east: the unrelenting Uzbek warlords had proclaimed the boy in Kabul their king.

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The Uzbek saga was drawing to its end. What kind of truce would hold